

Free will vs determinism



According to Christian belief, God allowed Adam the freedom to choose whether to eat the forbidden fruit. Although He is omnipotent, He has given us free will to decide our actions. But He is also omniscient. And if He knows what we are going to do, then our actions must be predestined, so how can we be said to have free will? The early Christian philosopher Boethius answered this by explaining that God's knowledge of our future actions does not prevent us from being free to make a choice. God foresees, but does not control, our thoughts and actions.

This problem has continued to occupy philosophers. On the one hand, there is determinism, the belief that everything that happens is determined by conditions so that nothing else *could* happen; on the other, the libertarian belief that we are free to choose our actions, and free will and determinism are incompatible. Somewhere in between are those who believe that our *choices* are determined but our decisions are our own – we are free to play the hand that we are dealt.